

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: A qualified foreign-policy framework

LABEL -> modern analytical shorthand for court diplomacy, frontier, trade and war
NOT -> nation-state + foreign ministry + permanent embassy + fixed legal border
CORE -> protect Indian revenue empire through Kabul and northwest balance
QUALIFY -> Timurid memory + rulerly honour + commercial interests + ambition
ACTORS -> emperor + princes + nobles + governors + envoys + merchants
METHOD -> claim -> named evidence -> mechanism -> source/region limit
BOUNDARY -> Topic 18 Deccan | Topics 20-23 internal/ruler-specific policy
MUST REMEMBER: Kandahar, Balkh-Badakhshan and relations with Safavids, Uzbeks and Ottomans
formed different strategic theatres.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: Northwest strategic geography

CORE -> Lahore/Multan -> Kabul -> Ghazni -> Qandahar -> Herat/Iran
NORTH -> Kabul -> Hindukush -> Balkh/Badakhshan -> Oxus/Transoxiana
QANDAHAR -> watered fort + road junction + Kabul shield + trade node
BALKH -> forward buffer/client zone; costlier than Qandahar
OXUS -> fordable near Balkh; not a self-enforcing scientific frontier
CONTROL -> fort + road/pass + stores + garrison + allies + relief + season
TRAP -> Qandahar/Kandahar is not ancient Gandhara.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: Four-court balance, not a sectarian bloc

UZBEKS -> displaced Timurids + contested Khurasan + threatened Kabul field

SAFAVIDS -> aid/counterweight/trade partner AND Qandahar rival

OTTOMANS -> West Asian prestige + Safavid rivalry + Red Sea/Gulf naval context

MUGHALS -> demanded equality and avoided exclusive dependence

1577 -> Akbar rejects law/religion difference as conquest ground

NO BLOC -> Iran checked Uzbeks; Uzbeks unreliable; Ottomans distant/superior

RULE -> state sectarian rhetoric, then test security, trade, distance and status.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: Diplomacy as message, intelligence and theatre

ELCHI / SAFIR -> temporary envoy, not permanent resident ambassador
LETTER -> victory/news/request/warning/friendship + formal status language
GIFTS -> horses + textiles + rarities stage rank and reciprocity
RECEPTION -> titles + robes + seating + embrace do not settle sovereignty
INFORMATION -> envoys + princes + nobles + merchants + frontier officers
TIME LAG -> slow news/order/relief raises value of local preparation
DISTINCTION -> courtesy != alliance != submission != abandoned claim.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: Akbar and the Uzbek balance

1572-73 -> Abdullah first takes Balkh | Shahrukh later recovers it
1577 -> anti-Safavid proposal refused; strong Iran checks Uzbek pressure
1583 -> Abdullah retakes Balkh | 1585 -> Badakhshan + Kabul annexed
FRONTIER -> Roshanai/Jalala/Yusufzai agency + Atak + Birbal loss
HAKIM HUMAM -> practical Hindukush accommodation, not final claim surrender
1591 -> golden key preferred | 1595 -> Qandahar transfer/surrender
1598 -> Abdullah dies; Shah Abbas recovers Khurasan; balance changes.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: Why Qandahar mattered

SECURITY -> strong watered fort + southern-Afghan junction + outer Kabul bastion

ROUTES -> Kabul/Herat + Multan/Indus/sea + wider Iran-Central Asia network

COMMERCE -> horses + textiles + gifts + customs + merchant information

PRESTIGE -> Timurid memory and imperial honour remain real

ASYMMETRY -> more vital Mughal bastion; important Iranian outpost

ALTERNATIVES -> sea + Sind + Iranian roads prevent route-monopoly claims

VERDICT -> defence + trade + prestige; never one cause alone.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Jahangir and the loss of 1622

1611 -> Shah Abbas embassy/gifts | Khan Alam return mission

TRADE -> Muhammad Hussain Chalabi + Multani/Hindu/Jain merchant presence

1620+ -> Persian envoys repeat Qandahar claim; cordiality hides no surrender

1622 -> Safavid initiative + Mughal unreadiness + relief/command problem

NUMBERS -> Iqbalnama 3,000 troops | Tuzuk 300/400 servants; keep separate

COURT -> Khurram coordination matters; Nur Jahan monocause rejected

LESSON -> diplomacy cannot replace prepared fort, commander and relief.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Shah Jahan recovers Qandahar in 1638

1628 -> Nazr Muhammad attacks Kabul; Mughal relief and diplomacy isolate him

1636 -> Shah Jahan proposes three-sided pressure to Ottoman Murad IV

LIMIT -> Uzbeks unreliable + Ottomans distant + superiority claim unwelcome

1638 -> Ali Mardan Khan defects/transfers Qandahar to Mughal control

DIPLOMACY -> embassies and offered revenue-equivalent payment continue

1642 -> Shah Safi dies during recovery movement; immediate threat recedes

RULE -> political transfer and diplomacy, not conquest of Persia.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: Balkh 1646-47: forward defence meets limits

1645 -> Nazr Muhammad appeals against Abdul Aziz; client/buffer opportunity

1646 FORCE -> Part II: 50,000 horse + 10,000 foot; attribute the figure

MURAD -> coercive entry makes Nazr flee; client design becomes occupation

1647 -> Aurangzeb pickets/mobile artillery rout Uzbeks outside Balkh

LIMITS -> hostility + no client + winter + forage + supply + noble reluctance

OCT 1647 -> withdrawal; Aurangzeb prevents retreat becoming disaster

VERDICT -> military success, political-logistical unsustainability.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: Why Qandahar resisted recovery, 1649-53

1649 -> Shah Abbas II recovers Qandahar; Aurangzeb's first attempt fails

1652 -> Aurangzeb's second attempt fails | 1653 -> Dara's attempt fails

FORT -> water + stores + walls + determined Safavid command

SIEGE -> guns/engineering/time differ from open-field cavalry battle

SUPPLY -> Lahore distance + scorched earth + fodder/grain/powder burden

SEASON -> winter closes the campaign window; heavy guns do not ensure breach

TRAP -> specific siege limit, not generic Mughal artillery weakness.

CLOSE DISTINCTION: Kandahar was a fortress-route-commercial hinge, not merely a prestige symbol in a modern border dispute.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Evidence and the bounded modern bridge

BABURNAMA / HUMAYUNNAMA -> memory/household-exile; positioned narratives

AKBARNAMA / AIN -> policy/geography; imperial and normative lenses

TUZUK / IQBALNAMA -> Jahangir persona + conflicting garrison claims

PADSHAHNAMA / LAHORI -> campaign + noble reluctance; patronage/victory rhetoric

RIVAL/EMBASSY -> Safavid/Uzbek/Ottoman letters + gifts reveal chosen claims

MATERIAL -> coins/inscriptions/forts/routes show claim/capacity, not motive

CURRENT -> predecessor India-Iran link is analogy only, never continuity.

EVIDENCE LIMIT: Mughal diplomacy used dynastic, commercial and frontier logics; it should not be recast as modern nation-state policy.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: Topic 19 final answer spine

DEFINE -> qualified court diplomacy; no modern state/border projection

MAP -> Indian core -> Kabul-Ghazni-Qandahar; Balkh/Badakhshan beyond

TRACE -> 1577 -> 1585 -> 1595 -> 1622 -> 1638 -> 1646-47 -> 1649-53

EXPLAIN -> balance + security + trade + prestige + feasible military reach

DISTINGUISH -> embassy/alliance/client/occupation/annexation/control

PYQ -> zero direct 2018-2026 | adjacent 2020 GS-I Q12 owned Topic 24

DEBATE -> India-centred baseline; Timurid ambition/adventurism qualifies it

VERDICT -> victory lasted only with supply, local legitimacy and sound design.